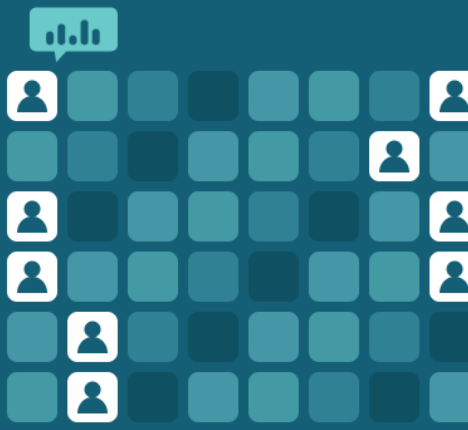
Place-based data training

Activities workbook

Module 1.3: Indigenous Data Sovereignty



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings together the activities for this module.

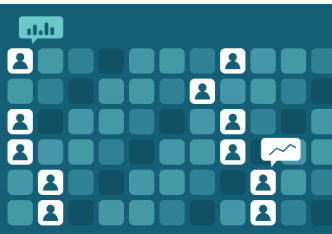
You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics



Module

1.3 Indigenous Data Sovereignty

Section 1	Understanding Indigenous Data Sovereignty	2 activities
Section 2	Core Indigenous Data Sovereignty principles and the data lifecycle	2 activities
Section 3	Frameworks, guidance and examples in practice	2 activities

Try this now: name the piece of work you will use

Try this now Apply to your place 1

Pick one piece of work you are involved in now where data connected to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people is used. Write it in the first column, then work across. Name which of the four **data buckets** it involves. Write who holds the data now, and, separately, who holds the authority over it, which are often not the same.

In the last column, write one decision in this work that is not yours to make. If you are not sure about some of the responses, this can be a good time to pause and take the time to find out. If you are not working with data connected to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people right now, use this example instead, and keep using it through the module: your organisation works with several others in a regional town on youth wellbeing.

A government department holds five years of service data for the area, some of it about Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander young people. Your group has been offered access to it for a shared report, and a first meeting is in three weeks.

The piece of work I will use	Which data bucket it involves	Who holds it now / who holds authority over it	One decision here that is not mine to make

PBD 1.3 · Section 1 Understanding Indigenous Data Sovereignty

Try this now: name the benefit and the risk

Try this now Apply to your place 2

Go back to the piece of work you named in the earlier exercise. Pick the one benefit above that this work could most realistically support, and the one risk above that is closest if nothing changes. Use the words from the lists, because those are the words a custodian will recognise.

Then name who would need to help decide this and might not be in the conversation yet; a role is enough. If you are unsure, this can be a good point to pause and dig further.

The benefit this work could support	The risk if it is not addressed	Who needs to be in this conversation and is not	One thing I will do this month

Try this now: test your work against the principles

Try this now Apply to your place 1

Take the piece of work from Section 1. Name which of the five Maiam nayri Wingara rights it most affects: control, contextual data, relevance, accountability, or protection. Name which CARE principle it most affects: collective benefit, authority to control, responsibility, or ethics.

Then consider and write how this could be demonstrated. E.g. “A data sharing agreement that names who decides” is something you can show. Finish by considering who in the community you work with/could work with to validate this.

The Maiam nayri Wingara right it most affects	The CARE principle it most affects	How could this be demonstrated?	Who can help validate

Try this now: turning principles into practice

Try this now Apply to your place 2

Return to the example from Section 1 and think about the rights, principles and data you identified in the previous activity.

Consider where Indigenous Data Sovereignty could be strengthened in this work. As you complete the table, you may find it helpful to revisit the descriptions of FPIC, Priority Reform Four, and the Framework for Governance of Indigenous Data.

These approaches provide examples of how governance, capability-building, data access, partnerships and consent can support Indigenous Data Sovereignty in practice.

Area	What could be strengthened?	One practical next step
Partnerships and shared decision-making		
Capability and leadership		
Access to data and information		
Data systems, processes or governance		

Try this now: use frameworks to support community direction

Try this now | Apply to your place 1

Frameworks should support Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander authority, not replace it. Always begin by asking the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community, organisation or ACCO what they want and how they want data to be governed.

Then identify which framework, code, commitment or initiative can help you advocate for that direction with someone in your own sphere of influence, such as your executive, a funder, a government agency or a data custodian.

Choose a situation connected to your work and note: What has the community or ACCO asked for? Who needs to support or act on that request? Which framework or commitment strengthens the case? And what would you say to that decision-maker?

What has the community/ACCO asked for?	Who needs to support the request?	Which framework, code, commitment or initiative strengthens the case?	What would you say to the decision-maker/data custodian?

Try this now: applying Indigenous Data Sovereignty in your work

Try this now | Apply to your place 2

The case studies illustrate different ways Indigenous Data Sovereignty can be reflected in practice, including community leadership, governance, strengths-based approaches, local capability, and community ownership of data.

Think about a place-based initiative, project or partnership you are involved in. What would need to change for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people to have greater authority over decisions about data?

If you're not sure, think about what you would need to ask or learn to better understand community priorities and aspirations.

The change needed (or question to explore)	Policy, process or culture change	Whose support is needed	The first conversation, and when